and Hoshangabad. Felling is a major concern in the central districts of Sehore and Raisen too. Of late, Vidisha district and in particular its four forest ranges—Lateri South, Lateri North, Shamshabad and Sironj—have been badly hit. Around 20 per cent of MP's total forest area is covered by teak trees while roughly 45 per cent of the forests in Vidisha district have these trees.

A total of 829 cases of illegal felling were registered in Vidisha in 2020, followed by 638 in 2021, and 217 cases till July this year in which timber worth lakhs of rupees has been seized. The district has lost nearly 30 per cent of its forest area to encroachment and illegal felling. Trees are seen only on the hills with the flat lands being under cultivation.

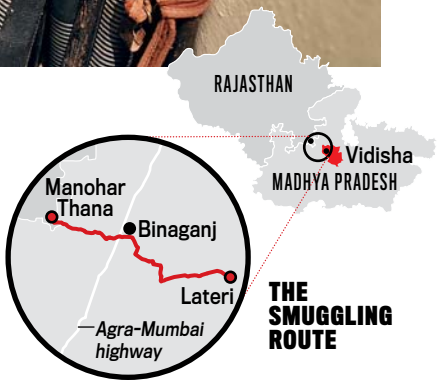
The punishment for illegal felling and transportation is also not a deterrent. The accused are usually booked under the Indian Forest Act, 1927, which attracts a maximum sentence of six months and is easily bailable. However, the state government, through an amendment, has raised the fine from Rs 5,000 to Rs 15,000. The alleged timber smuggler who was killed on August 9 had a previous case of felling against him. The answer perhaps lies in the more stringent laws such as the Wild Life (Protection) Act and the Biological Diversity Act. Relevant sections under both the acts are non-bailable.



GATHERING DUST Shotguns surrendered by forest department personnel stocked at the Lateri Range Office

STATE OF THE TEAKONOMY

MP has some of the best teak in the world, which is in great demand in the furniture industry



TOTAL FOREST AREA

VIDISHA
102,000
HECTARES

MADHYA PRADESH
7,749,260
HECTARES

TOTAL TEAK FOREST AREA

VIDISHA
44,744
HECTARES

MADHYA PRADESH
1,617,330
HECTARES

Source: MP Forest Department

THE MODUS OPERANDI

Timber smuggling has taken the form of organised crime in MP, operating through inter-state gangs. An intricate network of tree cutters, transporters, vehicle lifters and consumers work in conjunction. The gang members, around 50-70 on 25-40 motorcycles, identify a forest. They return to the site around 2 pm, carrying axes, petrol-powered and electric saws and weapons such as country-made pistols. After cutting and shaping the timber in planks called *sillis*, they move out after dark, delivering the goods across the state border.

There are two main locations where the illegally cut teak is sold—Manohar Thana in Jhalawar, Rajasthan, and Suthaliya in the Rajgarh district of MP. The latter has a number of furniture makers, while at the former, traders are said to assemble to buy timber, which is then supplied elsewhere. Timber is smuggled into Rajasthan on bikes, with the pillion riders at times holding three to four planks over distances ranging from 100 to 120 km.

Stolen motorcycles are an integral part of the racket. "Bikes lifted from urban areas such as Indore and Bhopal are sold for as little as Rs 5,000 in villages. Registration and chassis numbers are deleted and even when impounded the bikes are a dead end to find the culprits because there are no records," says Lateri North RO Swami. The Lateri police had busted a gang recently and arrested Nirbhay, a local supplier of stolen bikes. "We recovered 14 planks of teak and one bike from the spot where the alleged shooting took place. The bike has no details on it and cannot be traced to anyone," says Lateri police station incharge Kashiram Kushwaha.

The other 'development' that is aiding the racket is the network of village roads that has come up under the PM Gram Sadak Yojana. These roads help